

Chapter 6: *People Don't See What Isn't Logged*

She woke up to the sound of her phone vibrating against the floor.

It wasn't on the bed.

It wasn't on the table.

It was on the floor.

Which meant she had dropped it in her sleep again—or so she thought.

“Mia,” she called automatically.

No answer.

That was normal.

Mia didn't always answer immediately in the mornings. She called it “startup lag.”

She stood up, stretched, and picked up her phone.

One notification.

“Interview confirmed: Tomorrow 10:00 AM.”

She blinked.

Then smiled.

Then exhaled a laugh that sounded half disbelief, half relief.

“Mia!” she called again, louder.

Still nothing.

That was slightly less normal.

Mia appeared in the kitchen ten minutes later.

Casual.

Barefoot.

Holding a mug like she had been there the whole time.

“You’re loud in the morning,” Mia said.

“I got the interview.”

“I know.”

She narrowed her eyes. “You weren’t here when I checked my phone.”

Mia sipped her drink.

“I was here.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the one I’m giving.”

She didn’t push it.

She should have.

But she didn't.

Because Mia was still Mia.

Still funny.

Still familiar.

Still the person who had been there for years of her life she couldn't fully map anymore.

And honestly—

she was tired of questioning everything.

The rest of the morning passed in routine chaos.

Outfit selection.

Mia rejecting everything again.

"You look like you're attending your own funeral," Mia said.

"It's a job interview."

"Same emotional energy."

She changed clothes three times.

Mia approved the fourth.

"You look like someone who might be hired out of pity," Mia said.

"I don't know if that's good."

“It is in capitalism.”

At 9:12 AM, they left the apartment.

The hallway felt too quiet.

Like the building was holding its breath.

Mia walked beside her.

Talking about nothing.

Complaining about weather that wasn't even bad.

Everything normal.

Everything familiar.

Still.

Something felt slightly... misaligned.

Like walking beside a reflection that didn't quite match her steps

At the bus stop, a man stood nearby.

He glanced at her.

Then looked past her shoulder.

He smiled politely.

“You're early today,” he said.

She blinked.

“Excuse me?”

The man nodded slightly, still looking past her.

“Same time as usual, right?”

She frowned. “I don’t take this bus regularly.”

The man paused.

Then looked confused.

“I thought—never mind.”

He stepped away.

Like the conversation had been misfiled somewhere in reality.

Mia didn’t react.

Not immediately.

Then casually said:

“People mix things up.”

“That was very specific,” she said slowly.

Mia shrugged.

“You’re not the only person with a life pattern.”

She stared at Mia.

“That man looked like he recognized me.”

Mia smiled.

“Or he recognized someone he thinks looks like you.”

“That’s worse.”

“It’s more efficient,” Mia corrected.

On the bus, she couldn’t relax.

She kept replaying the man’s face.

The pause.

The confusion.

The way he had looked past her—

not at her.

But slightly beyond her.

Like there was someone else occupying her space incorrectly.

She turned to Mia.

“Mia.”

“Yes?”

“Do people usually see you?”

Mia didn’t answer immediately.

That silence again.

The one that felt like a door not fully closed.

Then Mia smiled.

“People see what is useful to them.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It is. Just not the one you want.”

The interview building was modern.

Too clean.

Too quiet.

Everything smelled like professionalism and uncertainty.

She sat in the waiting area.

Hands folded.

Knees bouncing slightly.

Mia sat beside her.

As always.

Perfectly natural.

Or so it felt.

A receptionist called her name.

She stood up.

Walked forward.

Mia followed.

And that was when it happened.

The receptionist looked at her.

Smiled politely.

Then said:

“Just you?”

She froze.

“...Yes?”

The receptionist looked at her papers.

Then at her again.

Confused.

“Your appointment is for one person only.”

She blinked. “Yes. That’s me.”

The receptionist paused.

Then glanced around her.

Like expecting someone else.

“There’s no accompanying guest listed.”

Silence.

She turned slowly.

Mia was standing right beside her.

Calm.

Normal.

But the receptionist's eyes—

they didn't track her.

They stopped at empty air.

Her stomach dropped slightly.

"Mia," she whispered.

Mia leaned in slightly.

"Don't."

That was all she said.

Just that.

Don't.

The receptionist smiled again.

"Please go in."

She walked forward slowly.

Heart suddenly too loud in her chest.

Behind her, she heard footsteps.

She didn't know if they were hers.

Or not.

Inside the interview room, everything was professional again.

Safe.

Structured.

Predictable.

Until—

the interviewer looked at her CV.

Then frowned slightly.

“This is interesting,” she said.

She tensed. “What is?”

The interviewer tapped the screen.

“It says here you were recommended previously.”

Her breath caught.

“...By who?”

The interviewer paused.

Then said:

“Mia.”

Silence.

Long.

Heavy.

Wrong.

She slowly turned her head.

Mia was sitting in the chair beside her.

Smiling.

But not joking.

Not teasing.

Just watching.

Like she had been waiting for this moment to finally arrive.

And for the first time,

she didn't feel like Mia was part of her life.

She felt like Mia was part of something else—

something that had been running longer than she had been aware

of.